ARGENTINE BLACK-AND-WHITE TEGU

Salvator merianae

What can I see or hear?
Its forked tongue tastes the air, its nose finds bugs under leaves, and it feels ground vibrations.

Where does it live, and why?
It lives in forest edges and savanna, digging deep burrows for shelter, winter rest, and eggs.

How does it send messages?
It hisses when cornered, puffs up its body at rivals, and males leave scent trails for females.

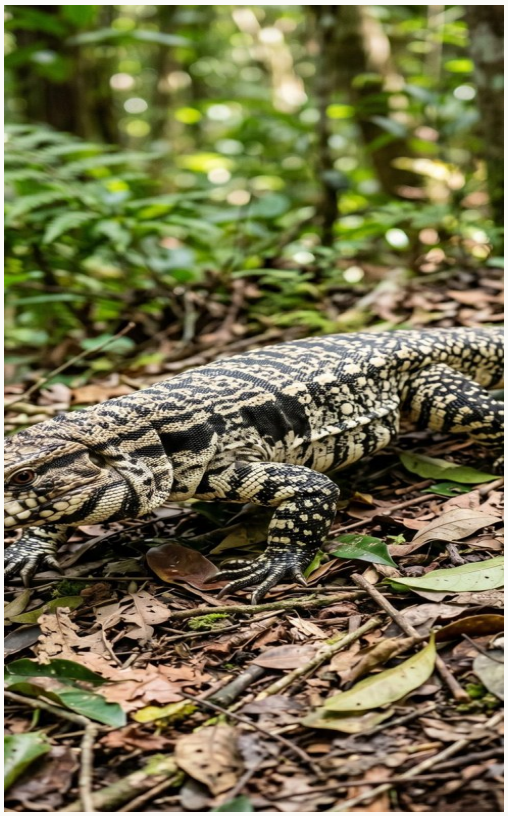
What does it do when something changes?
If threatened, it runs or stands and hisses; in cold months, it rests in its burrow without eating.

How does it learn?
Young tegus hatch alone and learn by trying — flicking their tongue to check new things.

How does it have babies?
A mother lays eggs in a burrow or termite mound and guards the nest with her own body heat.

What are the limits?
Without warm basking spots, it cannot digest food, and cold forces it underground for months.

What does this teach us?
Activity, digestion, and having babies all tie directly to temperature for this lizard.



Think About This
If your tongue could taste the air to find food, where would you point it first?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality. Environment shapes design.